



**cover story** GUJARAT ELECTIONS

# SURVIVAL OF THE STRONGEST

**As both Congress and BJP suffer from an acute shortage of leaders who have direct access to the mass mind, the rise of politicians like Modi and Mayawati brings out the sway of mighty mesmerisers**

■ By Prabhu Chawla

**A**n army without a general has never fought or won a war. This simple truth continues to be multiplied with devastating effect in Indian politics today. India's Grand Old Party was badly mauled in Gujarat because it was, to put it mildly, a headless army. As Narendra Modi roamed and roared, there was no marksman on the other side of the political divide to hunt him down. Faceless resistance to Force Modi crumbled, and the mask of Modi became the master card for renewing the mandate. Here was an individual with an ideology—and ideas. A kinetic leader who is always there in the vanguard. A politician whose slogan is matched by his agenda of change. Rarely has politics been defined by such a fine balance between personality and performance.

Lesson from Gujarat: what matters is not the party with a difference but the leader who makes a difference. Modi is adored and admired because he is perceived as a leader of aggression and enthusiasm, of conviction and combativeness. Tough leaders last longer than tougher times. Modi apart, where is the leader who stands tall and argues to change and conquer? Where is the leader whose text of salvation is larger than the political context? Look around and you see none in the Congress, at the Centre or in the states. The



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shock of Gujarat has brought out the empty core of the party—which doesn't mean, though, that BJP is conducive to the growth of strong regional leaders.

Take a look at the electoral verdicts of the last five years and you can't miss the trend: the vote is not for the party but for the Leader with a capital L. The leader who has direct access to the mass mind—and who delivers. The deadwoods have been mercilessly rejected. This year began with a big bang in the heartland, when Uttar Pradesh politics rhymed with Ma... Maya... Mayawati. A caste-driven party like BSP won an absolute majority for the first time. Not that the people were short of choices. The Gandhis campaigned desperately but Sonia and Rahul failed to ensure even an honorable defeat in what was once a Dynasty fief. The failure of L.K. Advani and Rajnath Singh was equally humiliating. It was a face-off between Mayawati and Mulayam Singh Yadav. Mayawati prevailed, and not entirely because of the



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